language, nobility of character. While humans, like all animals, have traits that set them apart—otherwise, how could we distinguish one species from another?—human uniqueness has been exaggerated, sometimes grossly so. Chimps reason, are self-conscious, make tools, show devotion, and so on. Chimps and humans have 99.6 percent of their active genes in common. (Ann Druyan and I run through the evidence in our book *Shadows of Forgotten Ancestors.)*

In popular culture, the very opposite position is also embraced, although it too is driven by human chauvinism (plus a failure of the imagination): Children's stories and cartoons make animals dress in clothes, live in houses, use knives and forks, and speak. The three bears sleep in beds. The owl and the pussycat go to sea in a beautiful pea-green boat. Dinosaur mothers cuddle their young. Pelicans deliver the mail. Dogs drive cars. A worm catches a thief. Pets have human names. Dolls, nutcrackers, cups, and saucers dance and have opinions. The dish runs away with the spoon. In the *Thomas the Tank Engine* series, we even have anthropomorphic locomotives and railway cars, charmingly portrayed. No matter what we're thinking about, animate or inanimate, we tend to invest it with human traits. We can't help ourselves. The images come readily to mind. Children are clearly fond of them.

When we talk about a "threatening" sky, a "troubled" sea, diamonds "resisting" being scratched, the Earth "attracting" a passing asteroid, or an atom being "excited," we are again drawn to a kind of animist worldview. We reify. Some ancient level of our thinking endows inanimate Nature with life, passions, and forethought.

The notion that the Earth is self-aware has lately been growing at the fringes of the "Gaia" hypothesis. But, this was a commonplace belief of both the ancient Greeks and the early Christians. Origen wondered whether "the earth also, according to its own nature, is accountable for some sin." A host of ancient scholars thought the stars alive. This was also the position of Origen, of St. Ambrose (the mentor of St. Augustine), and even, in a more qualified form, of St. Thomas Aquinas. The Stoic philosophical position on the Sun's